



somehow won, but I don't think I was mentally ready then. I learned so much from my two losses. The fact that I lost just 2-2 against a world champion gave me a lot of motivation. I realised how much more I had to work on," he says.

But that's not the only thing atypical about India's latest prospect in men's freestyle wrestling. He's a relatively late bloomer in the sport, only seriously pursuing it since the last five years. He once had dreams of being an engineer and routinely peppers his conversation with English.

Sujeet might have been expected to take to wrestling as a matter of tradition. He traces his roots to Imlota, a village in Haryana's Bhiwani district with a strong wrestling culture. His father, Dayanand, is a former national wrestling champion and even competed at the 2005 World Championships in the Greco-Roman category.

Sujeet, however, wasn't pushed into the sport. Although he started going to the village *akhara* with his father from the age of six, he, unlike many Indian wrestlers, was expected to give equal importance to his studies. Unable to focus solely on wrestling, Sujeet's career features no major success at the cadet (Under-17) or junior (U-19) levels.

"He scored over 90 per cent in his Class 12 Board Exams. Because he excelled in his studies, I didn't want to push him to wrestle the way he had to if he had to win at the age-group levels. *Kushti karwane aur sikhane me farak hai* (there's a kind of wrestling you do when you want to learn the sport, and a kind you do when you have to win). While Sujeet was in school, I just wanted him to

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